the formidable raider Mahmud of Ghazni, an event they apparently celebrated by commissioning the grandest Chandela temple of all, the Kandariya Mahadeva. However, nearly two centuries later, in 1202, the Chandelas fell to Qutbuddin Aibak of the Delhi Sultanate and became a vassal state. Thereafter, Chandela power continued to decline and they largely abandoned Khajuraho in the thirteenth century, retreating to their distant and formidable hill fort of Kalinjar, long associated with Shiva in mythology.

The ensuing political irrelevance of Khajuraho may be why its temples were largely ignored by the Turko-Afghan and later the Indo-Muslim kings of the Delhi Sultanate (1206–1526).[19] In 1335, however, the Moroccan traveller Ibn Battuta, who may or may not have visited Khajuraho, wrote about it and mentioned ‘temples containing idols which the Muslims have mutilated’, though, curiously, no such mutilation is evident in the extant temples. Battuta also mentioned yogis and healers with long clotted hair who apparently cured diseases like leprosy and elephantiasis. Within hundred years or so, long before the Mughals arrived, the great temple town of Khajuraho would drop out of history and memory to be mostly consumed by the forest.

Today, no trace remains of the dense jungle that had enveloped the temples. They’ve long been replaced by scrubland and agricultural villages, and more distantly, the arid forest of Panna National Park (which I visited one day from Khajuraho and was lucky to spot three tigers and a leopard). Khajuraho seems little changed from my previous visit thirteen years ago. Its population has risen a bit to 28,000, but its child sex ratio (0–6 age) declined from 91 to 89 per cent females between 2001 and 2011. It is rustic as ever: dogs and cattle roam the streets; traffic laws are rarely followed; people honk needlessly and blast loud music at odd hours; men pee on walls all over town; feral pigs rummage piles of refuse. Not a pretty place, but as I stoically remind myself, at least the people are hospitable, seem gainfully employed and the town feels safe for tourists. There are few decent eateries in town and no bars outside the luxury hotels, but nearly every eatery can arrange a quarter or half bottle of any IMFL upon request. One waiter cheerfully tells me, ‘No problem sir, this is India!’ I nod in happy agreement.